

Some of our newspapers and magazines are more concerned with the welfare of their advertisers than they are with the dissemination of news and the discussion of matters of lasting importance. I recall a recent edition of one well-known newspaper that devoted two fully and lavishly illustrated pages to an article purporting to prove that *Happier Gelatin Molding Makes for a Happier Home Life*. The same issue gave a three-paragraph report on a government crisis in a Latin American Republic, dispensed with a far-reaching change in Civil Defense policy in 11

lines, and allotted a scant half column to a resume of legislative action taken that week in the state capitol.

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Editorial policies? "It's rapidly reaching the point where you're allowed to take a strong stand in favor of mothers, babies and stray dogs, and against crime and spitting in the streets—and that's about all," a veteran newspaper editor complained bitterly to me not long ago. This, of course, is obviously an angry man's extravagant overstatement.

Nonetheless, it should be painfully apparent to any regular newspaper reader that there is at least some truth to what he says.

But newspapers and magazines are by no means the only —nor even the worst—offenders. Radio, television, motion pictures, popular books—all contribute their very considerable share to the conditioning process that leads to the stultification of thought and the stifling of dissent on all but the most banal levels. The extent to which some of these media will go to avoid controversy and to protect their own narrow interests is often incredible. It is graphically illustrated by a story I heard recently from a disgusted radio network executive. It appears that a large radio station killed a broadcast by a noted clergyman who was to have delivered a 15-minute talk on *The Sanctity of*

Marriage.

Why was the cleric ruled off the air? The president of a firm which bought considerable advertising air time from the station was then involved in a